

ON COURSE
A cruise that connects Hazira port in Surat and Diu island

ANI

In 2015, the government launched the ambitious Sagarmala project to capitalise on India's coastline and build infrastructure to connect different ports in the country. Sagarmala's investment target is at $123 billion—a maritime equivalent of the Golden Quadrilateral project for highways—under which 415 projects will be developed. It was in 2016 that the government passed the National Waterways Act and launched the National Inland Waterways Programme, declaring 111 rivers or river stretches as National (inland) Waterways. Until 2016, there were only five National Waterways—Ganga-Bhagirathi-Hooghly river system; Brahmaputra; West Coast Canal along with Udyogmandal and Champakara canals; Kakinada-Puducherry canals along with Godavari and Krishna rivers and East Coast Canal integrated with the Brahmani river and the Mahanadi delta rivers.

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The asct was intended to increase India's National Waterways from nearly 4,400 km to over 18,000 km. However, there are challenges that include building the waterways sustainably as the coastline is fragile and generating resources for the projects. Only three ports have been monetised so far, of the 13 identified. Overall, there has been an under-investment in inland waterways, compared to roads and railways. Inland waterways have also been neglected in successive five-year plans. It's imperative to bring the private sector to invest in this sector.

In 2021, the Inland Vessels Bill replaced the century-old Inland Vessels Act. There are 13 National Waterways that are operational currently, which carry 55 million tonnes of cargo every year. ■